Bagram. Kunduz was under Taliban and Pakistani control, whereas the United Front had overrun Bagram with US support. Despite American warnings against it, India had dispatched a team of intelligence officers, diplomats, and doctors (consisting of special envoy Satinder Lambah, joint secretary Arun K. Singh, chief liaison officer Gautam Mukhopadhaya, X, three army doctors, and three nurses) to restart diplomatic links with Kabul.[4] The Pakistani plane, however, undertook multiple sorties over the next few nights to evacuate hundreds of Pakistani soldiers (including, allegedly, two army generals), the Taliban leadership, ISI agents, and Al Qaeda figures.[5] Pakistan's airlift was hardly a secret given the heavy media presence around Kunduz, but the US Secretary of Defense, Donald Rumsfeld, and chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff General Richard Myers, bluntly denied any knowledge of it.[6]

An incensed India sent diplomatic notes to the UK and the US protesting the airlift, but no response was forthcoming. The R&AW had eavesdropped upon Musharraf's demand from the US for allowing the airlift as a quid pro quo for Pakistan's support in the Afghan war. National Security Advisor Brajesh Mishra decided against making the news public via government channels, for fear of upsetting US president George W. Bush (whose support was critical on various other issues including India's nuclear programme). Instead, he (along with R&AW officials) fed information about the airlift to investigative journalist Seymour Hersh, who reported it in the *New Yorker* on 28 January 2002.[7] But the damage had already been done. Within days, reports of thousands of militants waiting on Pakistan's side of the border began pouring in, about which Indian policymakers had full knowledge.[8] Though obliged under the UNSC resolution 1373 to desist from supporting any outfit or person involved in or linked with terrorism, Pakistan would not do it, argued India. This was mainly because Islamabad's support in Afghanistan was under US pressure, and 'not out of choice', argued Jaswant Singh.[9] Pakistan's duplicity, he emphasised, was clear when a series of failed assassination attempts were made on Afghan defence minister Mohammad Fahim and interim president Hamid Karzai.[10]

India's return to, and Pakistan's temporary exit from Afghanistan was a surreal, spectacular, and highly iconic moment that perfectly captured the strategic competition between New Delhi and Islamabad in Afghanistan. India